

That It Was

For my brother

That it was —

A raging headache
Dark circles
Shaky legs
Pillows, blankets on the floor
Eating ice cream
Watching *The Sandlot*
After the crying ran out

That it was —

A 12-inch phone cord
No shoelaces
Chicken and dumplings
Fluorescent lights
Forrest Gump in the rec room
A nineteen-year-old kid
There on her birthday
Screaming
for her fucking cigarettes

That it was not —

Stainless steel
Toe tag
Paper drape
Formaldehyde
That's him.
Can't breathe.
Slumping to the floor.

That it was not —

Finding your only suit
Buried
Behind your regular clothes
Reeling—
knees buckling because
everything still smells like you.

That it was not —

Stunned silence
Except when
the sobs punch through—
unexpected
violent
no warning
don't see it coming

That it was not —

Trying to choose which photos to use
I can't bear to look
Eyes refuse focus
Every time they see your image
blurring with fury
Pixels and ink—
all I have left.

That it was not —

Oak or cherry?
Open or closed?
What time on Saturday?
Are you serving lunch?

That it was not —

Blisters from the dress shoes I never wear
Dazed small talk with your coworkers
Sorry to be meeting under these circumstances
Thank you for coming
Drive safe
Here's your coat

That it was —

Blackout drunk
Before you found your keys
or grabbed the gun

That it was —

Crying with you
In the truck
In the kitchen
When you told us the truth
Cracked open
Decided to stay

That it was —

Shrimp Diabolo quesadillas at lunch
Wait—wasn't that what we used to call your ex?
Laughing for the first time since yesterday
Eyelids swollen, tear-brined like little
martini onions

That it was —

Going home
Running you a bath with
bergamot, salt, and rose
Making you tea
Walking the dog
Letting myself rest
For a few moments
Less afraid to leave you
alone

That it was —

Two days later
You scrubbed out the tub
And ran a bath
for me

That it was not —

You, in dead grass
Behind the firehouse
Like you'd planned
Your blazing aura now
inert
As blood pools around your head
A slow-spreading halo
Becomes a ring around your body:
You, at the center
Bullseye.

That it was —

The gun still in your bag
The last place she thought to look
Retrieved with bare hands
Warm
Shaking
Given to a friend
Locked away
Resolute

That it was not —

Zipped into plastic
By a stranger's gloved hands
Steady—
just doing his job
Going on break soon

That it was —

Her voice
Strange on the phone
He was on the floor
He was breathing
Bottle empty
Notes everywhere
Didn't know what to do,

so I called the cops
They took him in the ambulance
I'll know more soon

That it was —

On the plane the next day
Hadn't cried
Couldn't flinch
Just wanted to be with you
You didn't have to cook for me
It's okay. It helps me feel normal
Talked to the nurse
We can pick him up tomorrow

That it was —

We shared a womb
And a childhood
And are still
middle-aged together

That it was —

You were the tallest tree
In an open field

The lightning struck
And you let it

It split you in two

There were green shoots

Inside the dead wood

You chose to stay
To see what it might become

That it was —

A walk on the trail
Bursting with pollen

Texas January
Afternoon slanted sun
We laughed while you sneezed
Cedar season still kicks my ass

You're allergic
Because you're still breathing

You needed an antihistamine
And I had one

I give thanks
to anyone
anywhere
who is listening

By Abby Buchanan (2026)